Assignment Report

Individual Assignment 2: Persona

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00 Abstract

This report develops a persona during the early research stage of our group project. Using eight student interviews, I compare different user needs, select one persona, and explain how that persona could guide a digital arrival service for visiting students at USI.

01 System and design scope

Our group project explores the experiences of visiting and exchange students at USI in Lugano. For this individual exercise, I propose a **mobile-friendly arrival companion** that organizes common arrival tasks, explains where to find official housing and administrative information, and clarifies what students should do next.

02 Range of relevant user characteristics

The interviews revealed differences that affect the information students need. Table 1 summarizes five characteristics relevant to the proposed service.

Arrival stage	Some needed information before moving; others focused on registration, classes or activities after arrival.
Language ability	Some understood Italian instructions; others relied on English, translation or help from people around them.
Administrative needs	Visa, residence-permit and insurance procedures differed with each student's circumstances.
Accommodation	Some secured a room through USI Home; others searched privately when rooms were unavailable.
Information habits	Some valued email and ESN/WhatsApp groups; others struggled with scattered updates or unclear confirmations.

Table 1. Relevant characteristics derived from the eight interviews.

03 Design persona: Elina, the Prepared Newcomer

Figure 1 presents a fictional student whose needs represent a recurring pattern in the interviews.

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Elina, 22 | The Prepared Newcomer

Exchange student at USI | One semester in Lugano | Limited Italian

"I can fill in the forms. I need to know which steps apply to me and what happens after I submit them."

GOALS

Find housing, complete required procedures, manage classes and enjoy the semester.

FRUSTRATIONS

Unclear confirmations, uncertain response times, multiple portals and unfamiliar Italian instructions.

CURRENT BEHAVIOR

Checks official websites and email, translates instructions and asks peers or staff for help.

CORE NEED

A reliable overview of required steps, official contacts and expected follow-up.

Figure 1. Elina is a composite design persona, not an actual interview participant.

Why this persona?

I reviewed the eight interviews for recurring tasks, difficulties, workarounds and positive experiences. I grouped these findings into three possible user types and compared how well each would guide an arrival-focused service.

04 Selection and winnowing process

Table 2 shows the candidate personas and the primary need represented by each.

A. Prepared newcomer	Manages digital tasks independently but needs a clear sequence of administrative steps and expected confirmation.	**SELECTED**
B. Housing seeker	Needs reliable accommodation options when university rooms are unavailable.	Secondary
C. Social explorer	Wants to find suitable events and meet students without filtering excessive messages.	Secondary

Table 2. Three interview-based candidates and the selection decision.

Why Elina? Uncertainty about procedures, information sources and follow-up appeared across students with different backgrounds. This gives the Prepared Newcomer wider relevance to the proposed arrival service. Housing and social needs remain important but are narrower starting points. Several participants also praised USI's support; the aim is to clarify existing guidance, not assume that support is missing.

05 Evidence from the eight interviews

Table 3 links the persona to the research and includes contrasting experiences.

Interviews 1–2	Housing-application uncertainty, administrative feedback, language barriers and information spread across platforms.
Interviews 3–4	Rental paperwork and translations; student chats helped some but overwhelmed others. Interview 4 involved a full-degree student.
Interviews 5–6	Difficult local procedures and limited housing, alongside positive experiences with USI welcome support.
Interviews 7–8	Time-consuming visa/residence steps and missing insurance-paperwork confirmation, alongside useful staff or ESN support.

Table 3. Key interview findings informing and qualifying the persona.

06 Design implications and reflection

Example. Elina submits an insurance-related form but does not know whether to wait or contact an office. A useful service would explain the official process, provide verified guidance about the next step, and show the correct contact information.

Reflection. Comparing positive and difficult experiences helped me focus on making existing guidance easier to understand, rather than adding another communication channel. This also clarifies what information a first version of the service should prioritize.

Limitation. Eight qualitative interviews can inform an initial persona, but cannot establish how common each need is. The service and its information sources would require further validation.